MUSIC

For the Love of MOTHER EARTH

Themes as seemingly disparate as love and ecology find their way into *Skin*, Aditi Veena's forthcoming EP



Aditi Veena has spent the past few years exploring the connections between her day job as an urban ecologist and her passion for music. The Berlin-based musician—who performs as Ditty—excels at crafting delicate, intimate tunes that pull at the strings of our relationship with the natural world. Her 2019 debut album *Poetry Ceylon*, written when she was working as a conservation architect in Sri Lanka, incorporated samples of birdsong, crashing waves and buzzing insects into a raw, organic-sounding record about the island nation, its people and its non-human inhabitants. Four years later, she's back with 'Hold Me', the lead single off her forthcoming EP *Skin*, scheduled for release in March 2024. "I don't write many love songs, but this is one," says Veena. "I fell in love with my current partner and then we couldn't be together, so this is essentially a song about that feeling."

Veena's confessional, slow-burn vocals on 'Hold Me' showcase the sheer emotional power of her voice, which she's been putting to good use since she was 14 and singing as part of Delhi choir collective Artistes Unlimited. But it was her father's sudden death in 2014 that pushed her to write her own songs. Veena responded to the trauma of that moment by writing poetry to console herself.

"Then I taught myself to play the guitar, because I wanted to turn the poetry into song," she says. "I was really amazed by the strength I received from my musical expres-

FESTIVAL

THAT BANDRA SPIRIT

Jeet Thayil and **Anil Kably** have curated Five Oh, a poetry and indie music festival in Bandra



MANDAR DEODHAR

In the mid-aughts, Mumbai's Bandra was still in the process of transitioning to its NRI-and-white-expat-magnet-and-hipster-precinct era, but it was already where restaurants and watering holes came and went with bewildering rapidity. Many of the first wave of discotheques and pubs that launched in Mumbai post-liberalisation had downed their shutters for various reasons.

Around then, in

REVIVING THE GOOD OLD DAYS
(left) Anil Kably and Jeet Thayil, and a 2009 picture of the duo at a Zenzi event